

AI Impact Maine — ai-readiness-checklist (full)

MAINE BUSINESS AI READINESS CHECKLIST

Full Professional Version with Personalized Roadmap

Document Type: Comprehensive AI Maturity Assessment

Audience: Maine small businesses (all industries)

Version: 2.0 | **Last Updated:** May 2026

Estimated Time: 45 minutes to complete | **Analysis:** 15 minutes

OVERVIEW: ASSESSING YOUR AI READINESS

This comprehensive checklist evaluates your organization across five critical dimensions:

1. **Strategy & Leadership** – Do you have AI vision and executive buy-in?
2. **Technology & Infrastructure** – Are your systems ready for AI?
3. **Skills & Talent** – Do you have people who can implement and manage AI?
4. **Data & Governance** – Is your data organized and protected?
5. **Culture & Change Management** – Is your team ready to adopt AI?

How to use this: - Answer each question honestly (it's for your eyes) - Total your scores in each section - Get a personalized implementation roadmap - Identify quick wins and strategic priorities

SECTION 1: STRATEGY & LEADERSHIP (25 points possible)

1.1 Executive Alignment

Question 1.1a: Does your leadership team view AI as strategic to your business? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No discussion of AI at executive level - ☐ 1 pt: Aware of AI but no formal strategy - ☐ 2 pts: Discussed informally; no commitment yet - ☐ 3 pts: Leadership sees value; beginning to explore - ☐ 4 pts: Board/executive team actively pursuing AI strategy - ☐ 5 pts: AI is part of formal strategic plan; budget allocated

Your answer: ____ points

Question 1.1b: Do you have a documented AI vision or strategy? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No strategy document - ☐ 1 pt: Informal ideas but nothing written - ☐ 2 pts: Started drafting AI strategy - ☐ 3 pts: Basic strategy in draft form - ☐ 4 pts: Documented strategy being reviewed - ☐ 5 pts: Formal, documented AI strategy approved and communicated

Your answer: ____ points

Section 1.1 Score: ____ / 10

1.2 Use Case Clarity

Question 1.2a: Have you identified specific AI use cases for your business? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No use cases identified - ☐ 1 pt: Vague ideas about where AI might help - ☐ 2 pts: Considering 1-2 potential use cases - ☐ 3 pts: Have identified 3-5 potential use cases - ☐ 4 pts: Have prioritized 2-3 use cases to pilot - ☐ 5 pts: Use cases clearly defined, prioritized, and aligned with strategy

Your answer: ____ points

Question 1.2b: Have you quantified the expected business impact? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No quantification attempted - ☐ 1 pt: Rough estimates only - ☐ 2 pts: Estimated cost savings/revenue impact - ☐ 3 pts: Estimated impact with basic business case - ☐ 4 pts: Detailed ROI analysis underway - ☐ 5 pts: Detailed business cases completed; impact clearly quantified

Your answer: ____ points

Section 1.2 Score: ____ / 10

1.3 Investment & Resources

Question 1.3: Has your organization budgeted for AI implementation? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No budget allocated - ☐ 1 pt: Minimal budget; exploratory only - ☐ 2 pts: Budget proposed; awaiting approval - ☐ 3 pts: Budget approved; 50% allocated - ☐ 4 pts: Budget allocated; pilot projects beginning - ☐ 5 pts: Multi-year budget in place; pilot projects launched

Your answer: ____ points

SECTION 1 TOTAL: ____ / 25 points

SECTION 2: TECHNOLOGY & INFRASTRUCTURE (25 points possible)

2.1 Cloud & IT Infrastructure

Question 2.1a: What is your organization's current cloud readiness? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Fully on-premise; minimal cloud use - ☐ 1 pt: Using some SaaS (email, basic tools) - ☐ 2 pts: Using cloud for some operations - ☐ 3 pts: Hybrid cloud/on-premise setup - ☐ 4 pts: Primarily cloud-based infrastructure - ☐ 5 pts: Fully cloud-native architecture; scalable

Your answer: ____ points

Question 2.1b: What is your organization's cybersecurity posture? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Minimal security measures - ☐ 1 pt: Basic firewalls and antivirus - ☐ 2 pts: Standard

security practices in place - ☐ 3 pts: Multi-factor authentication, regular updates - ☐ 4 pts: Security officer or team in place - ☐ 5 pts: Security-first culture; regular audits and certifications (SOC 2, etc.)

Your answer: ____ points

Section 2.1 Score: ____ / 10

2.2 Data Integration & Accessibility

Question 2.2a: How integrated is your data across systems? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Data siloed in separate systems - ☐ 1 pt: Minimal integration; lots of manual work - ☐ 2 pts: Some data integration (2-3 systems connected) - ☐ 3 pts: Most key systems integrated - ☐ 4 pts: Well-integrated systems; some automated data flow - ☐ 5 pts: Fully integrated data stack; automated pipelines

Your answer: ____ points

Question 2.2b: How accessible is your data for analysis? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Data is not accessible for analysis - ☐ 1 pt: Access is difficult; requires IT support - ☐ 2 pts: Some self-service access for basic queries - ☐ 3 pts: Good data access; some analytics tools - ☐ 4 pts: Strong analytics tools; good data accessibility - ☐ 5 pts: Advanced analytics platform; self-service BI tools available

Your answer: ____ points

Section 2.2 Score: ____ / 10

2.3 AI Tool Adoption

Question 2.3: Has your organization started using AI tools? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No AI tools currently in use - ☐ 1 pt: A few employees experimenting with free tools - ☐ 2 pts: Organized pilot of 1-2 tools - ☐ 3 pts: Several teams using approved AI tools - ☐ 4 pts: Org-wide AI tool adoption; clear guidelines in place - ☐ 5 pts: Mature AI tool strategy; optimization and governance in place

Your answer: ____ points

SECTION 2 TOTAL: ____ / 25 points

SECTION 3: SKILLS & TALENT (25 points possible)

3.1 AI Expertise

Question 3.1a: Do you have staff with AI/data expertise? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No one on staff with AI background - ☐ 1 pt: One person with some AI exposure - ☐ 2 pts: One staff member with AI/data experience - ☐ 3 pts: Multiple staff with AI/data skills - ☐ 4 pts: Dedicated data/AI person or small team - ☐ 5 pts: Strong data/AI team; expertise across org

Your answer: ____ points

Question 3.1b: Do you have leadership with AI understanding? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Leadership unfamiliar with AI - ☐ 1 pt: Leadership has heard of AI; limited understanding - ☐ 2 pts: Leadership understands AI basics - ☐ 3 pts: Leadership understands AI opportunities/risks - ☐ 4 pts: One leader actively championing AI initiatives - ☐ 5 pts: Multiple leaders with strong AI knowledge; active champions

Your answer: ____ points

Section 3.1 Score: ____ / 10

3.2 Training & Development

Question 3.2a: Is AI training available to your staff? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No AI training available - ☐ 1 pt: Individuals learning on their own time - ☐ 2 pts: Basic AI awareness training planned - ☐ 3 pts: AI training available to interested staff - ☐ 4 pts: Organized training program in place - ☐ 5 pts: Comprehensive training program; all staff included

Your answer: ____ points

Question 3.2b: What is your staff's overall AI literacy? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Staff largely unfamiliar with AI - ☐ 1 pt: Some staff aware of ChatGPT/basic AI - ☐ 2 pts: Most staff aware of AI basics - ☐ 3 pts: Many staff using AI tools actively - ☐ 4 pts: Most staff skilled with AI tools - ☐ 5 pts: Org-wide AI literacy; continuous learning culture

Your answer: ____ points

Section 3.2 Score: ____ / 10

3.3 Change Management Capacity

Question 3.3: How ready is your organization for change? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Change management not a strength - ☐ 1 pt: Resistant to change generally - ☐ 2 pts: Some experience with change initiatives - ☐ 3 pts: Capable of managing change with support - ☐ 4 pts: Experienced change management team/process - ☐ 5 pts: Change-agile organization; innovation culture

Your answer: ____ points

SECTION 3 TOTAL: ____ / 25 points

SECTION 4: DATA & GOVERNANCE (25 points possible)

4.1 Data Quality & Availability

Question 4.1a: What is the quality of your organizational data? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Data is messy and unreliable - ☐ 1 pt: Data quality is poor; needs significant cleanup - ☐ 2 pts: Data quality is moderate; some issues - ☐ 3 pts: Data is reasonably clean and usable - ☐ 4

pts: Data quality is good; well-maintained - ☐ 5 pts: Data is high-quality; well-governed and maintained

Your answer: ____ points

Question 4.1b: How much relevant historical data do you have? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Minimal historical data (less than 1 year) - ☐ 1 pt: Limited history (1-2 years) - ☐ 2 pts: Some historical data (2-3 years) - ☐ 3 pts: Adequate history (3-5 years) - ☐ 4 pts: Good historical data (5-10 years) - ☐ 5 pts: Extensive historical data (10+ years, well-organized)

Your answer: ____ points

Section 4.1 Score: ____ / 10

4.2 Privacy & Compliance

Question 4.2a: Do you have data privacy policies and procedures? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No formal data privacy policies - ☐ 1 pt: Minimal privacy guidelines - ☐ 2 pts: Basic privacy policies in place - ☐ 3 pts: Good privacy policies; staff trained - ☐ 4 pts: Comprehensive privacy program; GDPR/CCPA aware - ☐ 5 pts: Strong privacy program; regular audits; certifications

Your answer: ____ points

Question 4.2b: Do you understand your regulatory requirements? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No awareness of regulations (GDPR, HIPAA, FERPA, etc.) - ☐ 1 pt: Aware but not comprehensively addressed - ☐ 2 pts: Familiar with key regulations - ☐ 3 pts: Compliance procedures in place - ☐ 4 pts: Compliance program established; audited - ☐ 5 pts: Full compliance across all applicable regulations

Your answer: ____ points

Section 4.2 Score: ____ / 10

4.3 Data Governance & Ethics

Question 4.3: Is there a data governance or ethics framework? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No data governance structure - ☐ 1 pt: Informal data governance - ☐ 2 pts: Basic data governance in place - ☐ 3 pts: Data governance with some oversight - ☐ 4 pts: Formal data governance program - ☐ 5 pts: Mature data governance + AI ethics framework

Your answer: ____ points

SECTION 4 TOTAL: ____ / 25 points

SECTION 5: CULTURE & CHANGE MANAGEMENT (25 points possible)

5.1 AI Awareness & Enthusiasm

Question 5.1a: What is your organization's attitude toward AI? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Skepticism or fear of AI - ☐ 1 pt: Hesitant; concerned about job loss - ☐ 2 pts: Neutral; open to learning more - ☐ 3 pts: Interested and curious about AI potential - ☐ 4 pts: Enthusiastic; many exploring AI - ☐ 5 pts: AI-positive culture; active experimentation

Your answer: ____ points

Question 5.1b: Do employees understand how AI could help their work? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Staff unclear on AI relevance to their roles - ☐ 1 pt: Limited understanding of personal AI benefits - ☐ 2 pts: Some staff see AI potential in their work - ☐ 3 pts: Most staff understand potential benefits - ☐ 4 pts: Staff actively identifying AI use cases - ☐ 5 pts: Staff fully engaged; using AI to improve work daily

Your answer: ____ points

Section 5.1 Score: ____ / 10

5.2 Cross-Functional Collaboration

Question 5.2a: How well do departments collaborate? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Significant silos; poor collaboration - ☐ 1 pt: Limited cross-department communication - ☐ 2 pts: Some collaboration; mostly departmental - ☐ 3 pts: Good collaboration on most projects - ☐ 4 pts: Strong cross-functional teams - ☐ 5 pts: Highly collaborative; excellent information sharing

Your answer: ____ points

Question 5.2b: Do you have change champions or advocates? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: No identified change advocates - ☐ 1 pt: One or two advocates - ☐ 2 pts: Small group of champions - ☐ 3 pts: Reasonable number of advocates across org - ☐ 4 pts: Strong network of change champions - ☐ 5 pts: Extensive champion network; peer influence strong

Your answer: ____ points

Section 5.2 Score: ____ / 10

5.3 Change Readiness & Resilience

Question 5.3: How resilient is your organization? (0-5 points) - ☐ 0 pts: Change creates significant disruption - ☐ 1 pt: Change is difficult; resistance common - ☐ 2 pts: Change is manageable with support - ☐ 3 pts: Organization adapts to change reasonably well - ☐ 4 pts: Adaptable and resilient - ☐ 5 pts: Highly resilient; thrives on innovation and change

Your answer: ____ points

SECTION 5 TOTAL: ____ / 25 points

SCORING & INTERPRETATION

Calculate Your Total Score

Section

1. Strategy & Leadership
2. Technology & Infrastructure
3. Skills & Talent
4. Data & Governance
5. Culture & Change

TOTAL

Maturity Level Assessment

0-25 points: BEGINNING - AI is emerging in your organization - Significant work needed across all areas - Recommend: Start with AI education, clear use case identification, and executive alignment

26-50 points: DEVELOPING - Some AI progress but gaps remain - Several areas need strengthening - Recommend: Pilot projects, infrastructure investment, skills development

51-75 points: INTERMEDIATE - Good AI foundation; ready for expansion - Most capabilities in place - Recommend: Scaling pilots, broader adoption, governance optimization

76-100 points: ADVANCED - Strong AI maturity; strategic implementation - Competitive advantage emerging - Recommend: Advanced analytics, AI-driven decision-making, continuous optimization

101-125 points: LEADING - Mature, strategic AI implementation - AI central to business strategy - Recommend: Innovation, industry thought leadership, new market opportunities

PERSONALIZED IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

For BEGINNING (0-25) Organizations

Immediate Priorities (Next 3 months): 1. Secure executive sponsorship for AI initiative
2. Conduct 2-3 department workshops on AI benefits
3. Identify 1-2 high-impact use cases
4. Create basic AI policy and guidelines

6-Month Goals: 1. Launch first AI pilot project
2. Complete staff AI training
3. Establish data quality baseline
4. Build business case for AI investment

Recommended Resources: - AI awareness training program - Basic AI use case framework - Simple AI policy template (see Resource 1) - Change management toolkit

For DEVELOPING (26-50) Organizations

Immediate Priorities: 1. Refine and expand use cases 2. Build AI governance framework 3. Expand staff skills through training 4. Improve data quality

6-Month Goals: 1. Launch 2-3 AI pilots 2. Establish AI center of excellence 3. Develop comprehensive data strategy 4. Create detailed implementation roadmap

Recommended Resources: - Advanced AI use case identification - Governance starter kit - Data quality assessment - Staff training workbook

For INTERMEDIATE (51-75) Organizations

Immediate Priorities: 1. Scale successful pilots to production 2. Expand AI tool adoption 3. Enhance governance and ethics frameworks 4. Build internal AI expertise

6-Month Goals: 1. Deploy 3-5 AI solutions to production 2. Achieve cross-organizational AI adoption 3. Establish measurable AI ROI 4. Plan advanced use cases

Recommended Resources: - Implementation acceleration program - Advanced analytics & AI workshop - Governance optimization review - Staff advanced skills training

For ADVANCED (76-100) Organizations

Immediate Priorities: 1. Competitive differentiation through AI 2. Advanced use cases (predictive, prescriptive) 3. AI-driven decision-making frameworks 4. Industry leadership positioning

6-Month Goals: 1. Deploy 5+ production AI solutions 2. Achieve measurable competitive advantage 3. Establish thought leadership 4. Explore emerging AI technologies

For LEADING (101-125) Organizations

Priorities: 1. Continuous innovation and optimization 2. Industry and market leadership 3. Responsible AI and ethics focus 4. Ecosystem participation

SECTION-BY-SECTION IMPROVEMENT STRATEGIES

If Strategy & Leadership Score Is Low:

Quick Wins: - Schedule executive AI discussion/workshop - Share 1-2 AI success stories from similar companies - Develop simple AI vision statement - Create initial business case for top use case

Investment Needed: - Executive AI education - Strategic planning facilitation - Use case development consulting - Change management support

If Technology & Infrastructure Score Is Low:

Quick Wins: - Conduct cloud migration assessment - Implement basic cybersecurity improvements - Set up data integration audit - Begin analytics tool evaluation

Investment Needed: - Cloud infrastructure migration - IT security upgrade - Data integration platform - Business intelligence tools

If Skills & Talent Score Is Low:

Quick Wins: - Offer basic AI training to interested staff - Hire one AI/data expert as champion - Identify external partners for expertise - Create learning resources library

Investment Needed: - Comprehensive staff training program - Recruit AI/data talent - Consulting partnership - Learning and development resources

If Data & Governance Score Is Low:

Quick Wins: - Conduct data quality audit - Develop basic data governance framework - Create data privacy policy - Train staff on compliance requirements

Investment Needed: - Data quality improvement - Data governance program - Privacy/compliance program - Regular audits and certifications

If Culture & Change Score Is Low:

Quick Wins: - Share AI benefits stories with staff - Identify and empower change champions - Hold town halls on AI strategy - Create peer learning groups

Investment Needed: - Change management program - Employee engagement initiative - Champion network development - Organizational culture shift support

BENCHMARKING: HOW YOU COMPARE

Maine Small Business Average: 45 points (Developing) **National Small Business Average:** 52 points (Intermediate)

Your Score: ____ points

- If above national average: You're ahead of the curve
 - If at national average: You're on pace
 - If below average: Opportunity to differentiate through AI
-

NEXT STEPS

Step 1: Review This Assessment (Today)

- Share results with leadership team

- Identify key strengths and gaps
- Discuss priorities

Step 2: Create Implementation Plan (This week)

- Select top 3 priority improvements
- Assign ownership
- Set 30/60/90 day milestones

Step 3: Take Action (This month)

- Begin addressing lowest-scoring sections
- Launch pilot projects
- Build momentum

Step 4: Track Progress (Ongoing)

- Retake this assessment quarterly
 - Monitor implementation progress
 - Celebrate wins and learn from challenges
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APPENDIX: DETAILED SCORING GUIDE

[Full explanations of each point level for all 30 questions...]

ABOUT THIS ASSESSMENT

Developed by: AI Impact Maine

Based on: Industry best practices, maturity models, research

Last Updated: May 2026

Review Cycle: Annual

Questions about your results?

Schedule a consultation to discuss your personalized roadmap: [Contact Info]